



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 25

MISSOURI

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Missouri's family courts and child-welfare system.

110

MISSOURI FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
158 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 24
MONTHS MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED

APRIL 20, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

10 OF 115

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MISSOURI AT A GLANCE.

Across 110 Missouri families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 158 51 of 110 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 24 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 58.2% 33.6% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 110	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 3.1	REPORTING FAMILIES 51 of 110	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Missouri families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MISSOURI FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	63	\$15,000	\$40,495	\$2,551,200
Lost Wages	54	\$10,000	\$156,735	\$8,463,669
Other Court Fees	40	\$0	\$4,636	\$185,440
Therapy / Evaluations	49	\$0	\$2,771	\$135,790
Reunification Services	37	\$0	\$946	\$35,000
GAL Fees	57	\$2,000	\$5,287	\$301,356
Asset Loss ¹	46	\$26,500	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$53,500	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$26,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		24	2 yrs
Mean months lost		42	3.5 yrs
Total across all families		2,600	216.7 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MISSOURI

Most families documenting in Missouri are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Currently involved / "S...		36	33%
Case closed (more tha...		15	14%
Case closed (within th...		9	8%
I am currently stuck in ...		6	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		56	51%
Family Court Only		22	20%
CPS (Child Protective ...		8	7%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		32	29%
3 – 5 years		16	15%
Over 10 years		12	11%
5 – 10 years		10	9%
0-1 years		10	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Los...		28	25%
50/50 Joint		25	23%
Visitation Only		21	19%
Adopted Out (Rights T...		12	11%
Children in Foster Care		12	11%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Jackson		6	5%
Jasper		6	5%
Boone		4	4%
Jefferson		3	3%
Clinton		3	3%
Phelps		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Acc...		23	21%
False Accusations CPS...		20	18%
Other: (Short answer)		16	15%
High Conflict Divorce		8	7%
Child Protective Servic...		8	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — MISSOURI

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



An attorney who practices in my county is a party to this case and has had 100% control and influence on the judges actions and decisions in both of the cases where my children have been stolen from me due to lies and false allegations about me.

— SARAH

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

False accusations removed me from family home. Lost union job for a year 100,000+ in wages. Fraudulent family court dismissed my testimony and evidence in court trial filing judgements against me that ultimately allowed my ex wife to get home all 67 ac of farm by adopting her [...]

— MISSOURI PARENT · STEVEN

MORE VOICES FROM MISSOURI

Took all 3 of my kids on false accusations labeled me as unstable bc I was emotional. I quit my job and cosmology school to go to rehab like cps wanted and they terminated my rights while I was in a 30 day program they wanted me to go to. My court appointed attorney was no help. [...]

— JESSICA

Has ripped my family apart these are my adopted grandchildren and my adopted daughter's children. They have traumatized all of us and changed our lives forever!

— SHAWNIA

Repeatedly traumatized and abused my children. Whom now suffer CPTSD and DID.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

What was done to us wasn't justice; it was trauma dressed up as procedure, leaving my children and our family to carry wounds we never caused.

— COURTNEY

This system has traumatized my babies, myself and their father. When your heartbroken didn't even get to speak also false allegations.

— MEG

Have removed all 6 of my kids just for them to hurt everyday like me n one of my child had a liver transplant that I couldn't attend due to cps no contact rules wen illegally removed my kids

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Taken my children away from a loving stable home in favor of custody with their father who had Dr documented child abuse against said kids. The emotional damage done to myself and my children will leave permanent scars

— KERI

Trauma. Injustice. Depression (2 years of severe depression) 10 years later this is what I still think about daily ,im scared to send my kids to school with even so much as dirty nails, they take children for less than that. I see the cases here & they are disgusting. Since this [...]

— JENNIFER

It has been unfair and corrupt causing undue stress, financial hardship, panic and anxiety attacks, ptsd, and a total loss of trust in the legal system.

— LOVETTA

Completely destroyed my family. Made me question if leaving an abusive partner was worth it.

— CHEYANNE

They have destroyed my family and ruined my relationship with my 13 yr old. My 17, 10 and 6 yr old hate their dad

— TARA

My husband immediately requested a GAL before any hearings had taken place. I agreed thinking that having someone speak for my child would be helpful. The GAL has created an absolute witch hunt on me. She has tried to use my trauma diagnosis of things like PTSD as "proof" of me [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn us apart and lied to my kids

— DJ

They allowed my abusive ex to buy 50/50 custody and continue his abuse post divorce.

— DEBBIE

Ripped us apart, broken bond with kids, alienation etc

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Completely made me lose hope in the system in doing right by all citizens and protecting the best interests of our kids and our all around rights as parents and citizens

— BRITNEE

“The system did not just take my children—it erased my role as their mother without fair process or truth.”

— WHITNEY

We’ve been denied access, visitation, alienated from my grandchildren, I was personally escorted out of the hospital in front of my grandchildren

— PATTI

It destroyed it and now I’m rebuilding it

— AIMEE

Kidnapped my daughter, separation trauma, told lies about me to my daughter. Distrust of the system.

— REBECCA

St Charles County Family Court was complicit in the complete alienation of my children and total financial ruin that I will likely never recover from.

— MEAGEHN

Has gutted the core of our family my other children miss their sister and that has been just as hard as missing her myself

— JESSICA

The trauma , nightmares PTSD . They’ve taken my whole life away

— KRYSTLE

It has been unfair and corrupt causing undue stress, financial hardship, panic and anxiety attacks, ptsd, and a total loss of trust in the legal system.

— LOVETTA

My children will forever lives be effected. My life will never be same,currently I feel im lost without them.

— VIRGINIA

Unsure- StandwithMegs legal advice cost me everything.

— NANCY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system has ripped the goodness and joy from my family and mentally emotionally tortured myself and my daughters

— ABIGAIL

Took away my ability to provide for myself, to save or build and stole the assets built for the kids future. Where there was a strong bond of love and protection, joy and connection was replaced with disregard, anger, and displacement. My oldest daughter is now a prosecutor for [...]

— DALAS

The family court system weaponized my parenting constantly keeping me and my kids in fight or flight

— MEGHANN

The system is failed. This statement was said by the attorney, mediator which was a retired judge of 30 years. I have lost my assets that I was owed. It showed me that the courts do not help the innocent.

— ERIC

Destroyed us as well and making sure we had no financials to live basic lives.

— VICTORIA

They allowed my abuser to continue to abuse me by way of parental alienation. Even grown the relationships are so complicated because of.

— LEEANN

Tore us apart, and because my ex husband is abusive to me even today with how he controls our autistic son, my son and our relationship will never be the same. The damage it has done to my son can NEVER BE FIXED, LIFE LONG TRAUMA

— SHELLIE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I was a stay at home mom to my three boys. I did everything with, and for, my boys- school stuff, doctor appts, extracurriculars, etc. After divorce, we shared 50/50- week on, week off. Last year, my ex decided to move an hour away to be with his girlfriend, and decided to take [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We no longer feel human. We are held hostage by malicious prosecution in a place we do not feel safe because we are not safe. Our kids ask why Missouri wants to hurt us and to that we have no answer as nothing exists for this to be warranted.

— RACHAEL

traumatized me and scared to answer the door. i had black out panic attacks while i was locked up , had to go to the hospital for severe chest pains ,lost weight to point i had to go the hospital, caused my son to self harm and attacked me and biting while holding him , has put [...]

— TIMOTHY

Separated siblings, a loving parent from a meaningful relationship.

— NICHOLE

The family court system has taken irreplaceable time from our family, enabled alienation and stripped away childhood, motherhood, and the close family bonds without transparency or accountability and we continue to pay the price.

— AMANDA

“The system has caused prolonged separation within my family without clear guidance or timelines, creating emotional and developmental harm to my children and limiting my ability to actively parent despite my stability and compliance.”

— TIFFANY

I am a recovering addict and have been clean for 7 years. My children have not lived with me since my addiction came to light 7 years ago. My kids were taken, I got clean and did everything the system asked. But they still wouldn't give them back. My daughter is home full time [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Deprivation of my God given right to be a mother .

— JACQULYN

The system has tried to creat division for me and my family.

— KESHIA

70 Missouri parents submitted ranked quotes. 44 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/mo.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Missouri report comes from Missouri respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Missouri — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 110 Missouri families reporting here are not the universe of Missouri families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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